Project 2: How are rhythm games so immersive?

I have a question. Why can streamers play the same rhythm game FOR 7. HOURS!? Why makes people stay up at night just to play rhythm games? **What is the juice that rhythm games have, to be on par with AAA titles in terms of immersion?**

Insert montage of clips

(show gameplay clips without music)
Have you ever tried playing a game without sound?

(silence)

It feels awkward, if not slightly inconvenient.

But why is there such a disconnect when you remove sound from rhythm games? You've just experienced this in the interactive demo. Did you feel the gameplay experience was smoother with music?

But why does this phenomenon almost happen exclusively for rhythm games?

It's because music transcends its normal role. Rhythm games are unique because music serves as a direct bridge between gameplay and the audiovisual experience. We call this link, "charting."

*Show a brief montage of rhythm game clips while music plays, and on screen, a brief definition of charting appears."
Charting = Process of creating sequences of notes mapped to the music.

I'm going to show you two clips of a chart for the same song. I want you to play close attention to the sequence of notes for each clip.

Show Clip A: mp3 randomly generated chart for 6 seconds
Show Clip B: human charted song for 6 seconds.

If you were astute enough, you would have noticed the first clip having a mismatch between the notes passing through the judgement line (highlight judgement line) and the music itself. This is because the first example was not charted by a human, but was randomly generated by a computer software. The notes are not synchronised with the music.

What this means, is that in every rhythm game and in every chart, notes are intentionally mapped to parts of the music. When you play a chart, it feels like you're performing music.

Part 3: Strive for self improvement / Positive feedback systems.

Valorant Players spend a lot of time practicing headshots. Headshots in FPS serve as what we call a “positive feedback loop” for player progression.

It’s really simple.

You get a headshot, you get adrenaline and dopamine for killing the enemy, you seek out more headshots.

But headshots are very luck based for newcomers. When players fluctuate between lucky headshots and misses from session to session, they do not see themselves visibly improving. This leads to player frustration and demotivation.

Frustration is your NUMBER ONE ENEMY. When you become frustrated, you become focused on the problems and limitations. Your attention shifts away from the experience. Frustration destroys immersion.

What if there was a system that minimises frustration by quantitatively measuring your performance?

Rhythm games have a scoring system which rewards more points for skill based gameplay. This system is made of many underlying components.

The first component is timing windows. Timing windows are an inherent characteristic of every note. They are time periods in which the player must input an action to score a note. The closer the input is to the “true” timing window, the higher the score.

I think the amazing design behind timing windows is the relative lack of punishment for mistakes. A mistake in a rhythm game results in a small deduction in the score that you can shrug off. A mistake in a multiplayer game, leads to teammates yelling at you. A mistake in an RPG causes walled progression.

It’s this leniency that produces a comfort zone that makes it very easy to be immersed. It’s the same philosophy behind cozy games like Stardew Valley where there’s not really a deadline or hurdle you must overcome. And you know how many hours the average stardew valley player has.

Rhythm games blend casual and competitive games. They allow players to arbitrarily choose their own sweet spot.

While talking next section, the screen demonstrates some examples of this

Let’s talk about audiovisual cues next. Whenever you hit a note, you get a text and a sound effect.

The text states whether your timing was accurate. The sound effects play depending on what note you just hit and sometimes the timing of that note.

This is instantaneous player feedback. Rhythm games constantly remind the player every note they just hit. Every incremental amount of progress they make. And at high levels, the player can use audiovisual cues to reflexively adjust whilst playing.

(Screen: Thinking: I am hitting notes too late. I will hit the next notes earlier.)

This is amazing! It's like a chess player reviewing their game using a chess engine. It prevents the player from going down the wrong path in the first place and forming bad habits. Do you know the utter frustration of playing a game for five years and realising that you have to unlearn everything to fix your fundamentals? Why don't more games do something similar and implement anti-frustration strategies?

Part 4: Performative play.
This section requires specific clips of players doing funny / wacky things. I can source the clips. E.g. One hand cytus clip.

I want you to take a look at this clip here. Pay attention to the players on the left side.

Here's the "standard" approach to this chart.

I want you to take a moment and think. What was different in the first clip compared to the second?

(Insert multiple choice pop quiz here)
A Different song
B Different rhythm game
C There is no difference.
D Different player movements

I hoped you pick D, because that's the right answer.

In the first clip, players were doing what I personally call "performative play". These are extra actions that players do that the game does not actively reward. Now, this might seem counterintuitive. Why engage in something may hinder player concentration?

Have you tried playing with a pencil while doing your homework? (real life footage) It's the same idea.

Performative play helps the player focus. There are players who press keys at the start of a chart to ensure they have the correct hand placements. There are players who tap to maintain

their internal rhythm when there are no notes. There are people who jam because they are have an amazing time. Immersion has always been ambiguous, but a rhythm gamer jamming to the music is as clear cut as it can be.

And rhythm games encourage this by having player freedom baked into a chart. What do I mean by this?

This is one of the basic patterns in a rhythm game. It's called a stair because these are four sequential notes in a stair-like shape which have to be tapped.

You can choose to hit all four notes using one hand (left or right). You can hit two notes using your left hand and two with your right. You can alternate left and right hands. There's so many different approaches.

What this means is that a chart has no singular correct approach. Rather, a player chooses their own personal approach to reach the end goal. They can choose to do all sorts of stupid and wacky things and still reach the end goal.

Forget Open World games, this is true player freedom.

Part 5: Conclusion

I feel sad when I mention rhythm games and people immediately think of piano tiles, friday night funkin and geometry dash (which is not a rhythm game). People are missing out on this niche video game genre.

There's so much potential, components, mechanics that we can learn or be inspired from, whether to make better video games… or even, approaches to life.

(Credit Scene rolls)

References:

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